AJP Policy Document

Mitigate natural threats to wild animals

AJP recognises that wild animals often suffer from causes of natural origin. In many cases, intervention can be appropriate to protect wild animals from threats that they are not able to cope with.

There are many examples today of people and conservation agencies intervening to protect particularly endangered or charismatic species. For example, stranded whales or dolphins are often kept wet and efforts are made to refloat them;[1] lost penguins are transported back to Antarctica;[2] underweight yellow-eyed penguin/hoihoi chicks have been hand-reared until they can survive at sea;[3] and following cyclone Gabrielle, wildlife stranded in mud and floodwaters were rescued.[4] However, non-threatened and less charismatic species often suffer from similar threats. AJP wishes to see these existing efforts increased and expanded to other species. Research is also needed to understand the welfare of wild animals and how their flourishing can be ensured and legally protected.

Wild animal populations are especially impacted by natural disasters. For example, the Kaikōura earthquake disrupted marine ecosystems and seal colonies,[5] while increasingly frequent severe storms and flooding events have destroyed habitats and nesting sites of birds like the endangered wrybill.[6] Prolonged drought conditions have

[1] Department of Conservation. (2015). *Stranded whales and dolphins: How you can help*. Wellington, NZ: DOC. https://www.doc.govt.nz/documents/conservation/native-animals/marine-mammals/stranded-whales-dolphins.pdf
[2] National Institute of Water & Atmospheric Research (NIWA). (2011, September 4). *Goodbye Happy Feet – We wish you well* (release into Southern Ocean near Campbell Island from RV Tangaroa). https://niwa.co.nz/news/goodbye-happy-feet-we-wish-you-well
[3] Alden, B. (2016). *Summary of research funded in 2016: Supplementary feeding and post-fledging dispersal of hoiho/yellow-eyed penguins*. Birds New Zealand Research Fund. Retrieved from https://www.birdsnz.org.nz/wp-content/uploads/2019/02/1805-Summary-Article-YEP-Fledgling-Dispersal.pdf
[4] IFAW. (2023). *Animals rescued from New Zealand cyclone wreckage* [Press release]. International Fund for Animal Welfare. Retrieved from https://www.ifaw.org/press-releases/animal-rescue-nz-cyclone
[5] Schiel, D. R., Alestra, T., Gerrity, S., Orchard, S., Dunmore, R., Pirker, J., Lilley, S., & Tait, L. (2019). *The Kaikōura earthquake in southern New Zealand: Loss of connectivity of marine communities and the necessity of a cross-ecosystem perspective*. Aquatic Conservation: Marine and Freshwater Ecosystems, 29(9), 1520–1534. https://doi.org/10.1002/aqc.3122
[6] Dowding, J. E., et al. (2020). *Survival and breeding success of wrybills (Anarhynchus frontalis) in the Tekapo and Tasman Rivers, South Canterbury, New Zealand*. Notornis, 67, 755–764.

reduced food availability for many species,[7] and rising sea levels threaten coastal wildlife.[8] The increasing intensity of these events due to climate change compounds the suffering of wild animals who have no means to escape these disasters.

Wild animals also suffer frequently from less cataclysmic events. Many suffer from starvation, disease, harsh weather, or threats from other species or members of their own species.[9] While these threats are more challenging to address without disrupting ecosystems, the development of wild animal welfare science[10] will help us to understand these problems and may lead to better ways to promote the flourishing, and protection, of wild animals in the future.

AJP is committed to developing a comprehensive approach to protecting all wild animals from natural threats. We will encourage interventions during natural disasters, promote scientific research into wild animal welfare, and support volunteer rescue groups. Our policy aims to expand protection beyond endangered species to include all animals affected by natural threats, while establishing a national research institute dedicated to understanding and improving the lives of wild animals throughout Aotearoa.

Key Objectives:

1. Promote wild animal welfare science to better understand the lives of wild animals and how their flourishing and protection can be promoted.
2. Redefine the functions of the Ministry of the Environment to include the promotion of wild animal welfare.
3. Encourage other government and community agencies and local councils to consider the impacts of their policies on wild animal welfare where appropriate.

Interim Measures:

4. Establish protocols in local councils and environmental bodies for interventions to protect wild animals in the event of natural disasters.
5. Support volunteer groups that protect wild animals from natural threats.
6. Increase interventions to protect endangered species from natural threats.
7. Establishment of a national research institute for the study of wild animal welfare and the design and implementation of impact assessments and protection strategies.

[7] Department of Conservation. (n.d.). *Climate change impacts on our native wildlife*. https://www.doc.govt.nz/our-work/climate-change-and-conservation/climate-change-impacts-on-our-native-wildlife/
[8] Ministry for the Environment. (2023). *Our atmosphere and climate 2023: Outlooks*. https://environment.govt.nz/publications/our-atmosphere-and-climate-2023/outlooks/
[9] Horta, O. (2017). Animal suffering in nature: The case for intervention. *Environmental Ethics, 39(3)*, 261-279.
[10] For a definition and explanation of wild animal welfare science, see https://www.wildanimalinitiative.org/research-priorities#introduction